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Toys ‘R’ Us wants to come back and play

Banking on millennial nostalgia, retailer plans to open more, smaller outlets

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

Toys “R” Us kids may now be adults, but the retailer is hoping it can persuade a new generation to never “wanna grow up.”

After collapsing into bankruptcy a decade ago and closing thousands of stores, Toys “R” Us has returned to Greater Boston with a store inside South Shore Plaza in Braintree. It’s part of a plan to open 120 stores

nationwide this holiday season to revive the once-ubiquitous retailer.

But instead of the big-box toy-store empire many parents remember, the new stores are often smaller and only temporary, according to information obtained by the Globe that has not been previously detailed. The one in Braintree is about 5,000 square feet.

Some analysts are optimistic that the temporary Toys “R” Us can

tap into millennial nostalgia, which has revived ’90s and early 2000s trends in everything from music to clothing.

“I grew up going to Toys ‘R’ Us. It was a treat, and I had a blast every time. Now I’m the mom of an 8-year-old and a 3-year-old, and that’s exactly who this comeback is aimed at,” said Sharmin Attaran, a Bryant University marketing professor. “Parents like me want to hand that feeling to our kids.”

The comeback is being orchestrated by WHP Global, a private equity-backed brand management

company that acquired the controlling stake in Toys “R” Us in 2021. It is partnering with Go! Retail Group, a company known for seasonal retail, in the new stores.

Alex Winkelman, an executive vice president of Go! Retail Group, said the new stores will resonate.

“We are seeing great results,” said Winkelman, adding that most leases are for up to 12 months. “The customer absolutely loves Toys ‘R’ Us.”

WHP — which oversees other labels including Vera Wang, Express, **TOYS, Page A7**

Cost likely higher for commuter rail pact

Final bids are due today; Keolis among candidates

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

In 2014, MBTA leadership celebrated an “exciting new era” when it inked a contract with a French transportation company to run its 300-some miles of regional commuter rail service.

They knew it would not come cheap: The original deal estimated Keolis would receive \$4.2 billion, should the contract run its maximum length of 12 years.

It did. And it didn’t.

The T paid nearly \$1 billion more to Keolis through June 2025 to operate, maintain, and at times, shepherd improvements on the commuter rail. That comes out to about \$5.2 billion in all so far, but does not include the hundreds of millions the operator is expected to receive for the most recent fiscal year. (The T says that figure is not yet final.)

The escalating costs offer a glimpse into just how expensive it could be to keep trains moving under the T’s next contract. Final bids for a new nine-year deal to run the commuter rail are due Monday. By the end of the year, the T will decide whether Keolis or one of two other bidding groups deserve what could be the largest operating contract in Massachusetts history.

But regardless of which of the three competing companies emerges victorious, experts say the price **RAIL, Page A10**



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Paul Casey stepped gingerly into ocean foam stirred up by the storm Sunday as he checked on his brother’s house in Scituate.

Nor’easter whips up more winds, waves

Persistent storm batters coast, drenches state, leaving outages, flooding

By Allyson Chiu
GLOBE STAFF
and Katie Cressman and Sam Shipman
GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

A nor’easter lashed Massachusetts with drenching rain and heavy winds over the weekend, flooding some areas and knocking out power for thousands as the storm dumped several inches of badly needed rain on a region still gripped by drought.

The slow-moving storm delivered some of its heaviest rainfall in Southeastern Massachusetts and the Cape, where some totals reached more than 7 inches and wind gusts peaked at 70 miles per hour, according to Globe meteorologist Ken Mahan. New Bedford recorded 6.5 inches of rain while areas near Bourne hit 7.74 inches, Mahan said.

The powerful weather system caused damage in many communities, even as the torrential rain soaked soil that had been mostly dry for months.

“This is obviously really good news for the drought conditions, especially across Southeastern Massachusetts, which has been under severe drought for most of the summer,” said meteorologist Chris Gloninger, a senior climate scientist at the Woods Hole Group in Massa-

STORM, Page A10



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

A fallen tree was in pieces after being cleared from Doone Avenue in Boston amid the nor’easter on Sunday. Wind gusts peaked at 70 miles per hour in parts of Southeastern Massachusetts and Cape Cod.

Doug Burgum: secretary of pet projects

Official transforms once low-key Cabinet position

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — On a warm evening in early May, 10 black SUVs drove across the drained Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool. President Trump was making a surprise visit to check on the progress of his latest D.C. pet project, where blue sealant was being applied to the pool’s leaky floor.

The official in charge of the project, Secretary of the Interior Doug Burgum, was overdressed for the occasion. Summoned on his way to a benefit for the National Mall, Burgum, wearing a tuxedo, shined shoes, and a Ken doll-esque smile, stood behind Trump’s right shoulder as the president sang his praises.

“I want to thank Doug Burgum, the job he’s done,” Trump told reporters, “and we’re working on some other jobs that are great.”

The president has spent much of his second term directing an overhaul of Washington’s ico- **BURGUM, Page A6**



Pour track record

Monday: Flooding possible.
High 58-63, low 52-57.

Tuesday: Early rain, then clouds.
High 62-67, low 55-60.

High tide: 12:36, 12:51

Sunrise: 6:38. Sunset: 6:31.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **B6.**

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British officials said police halted a possible terrorist attack when they arrested five men in three vehicles heading toward an air force base used by the US military. **A4.**

Thousands of Mass. residents lost food assistance funds after being automatically disconnected when trying to call a caseworker through the state’s assistance line, according to a lawsuit. **B1.**

Ending a season of strange — and sometimes marvelous — twists, the Red Sox lost their finale, a home game played far away from home. But playoffs begin Tuesday. **C1.**

David Pastrnak will be the Bruins next captain, the first since Brad Marchand was dealt to the Florida Panthers 18 months ago. **C1.**

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A builder finds his foundation now imperiled

Immigrant slows work as status uncertain

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

On a sunny September Friday, carpenters, plumbers, and siding installers pounded nails and drilled boards at a three-unit condominium complex in Charlestown. It’s one of several jobs overseen by general contractor Jose Urias, whose construction company has built 150 housing units in a state in desperate need of more homes.

But the future of his 18-year-old company, and the completion of these projects, hinges entirely on President Trump. Urias’s Temporary Protected Status expired Sept. 9, along with that of 7,300 other Massachusetts residents from El Salvador. The administration has not announced if their sta- **CONTRACTOR, Page A7**

PATRIOT CLOUDS IN SUNSHINE STATE



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

New England Patriots quarterback Drake Maye walked off the field after throwing two interceptions in a 35-6 drubbing from the Jaguars Sunday at EverBank Stadium in Jacksonville. **C1.**